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Title:
Overcooked

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Overcooked

Two elderly neighbors are, once again, having a discussion which will lead inevitably to another argument. On one side is Fred Gunter, a very cynical, pessimistic, grouch. He is married to Gail, a quiet and sweet lady. She is an eternal optimist. She treads as lightly as possible when it comes to Fred's mood. On the other side is Henry Meadows, a polite and decent fellow. He is married to Iris, a loud, abrasive temperamental woman. He treads lightly when it comes to Iris' unpredictable mood swings. The dynamic of the two marriages has always stirred up very colorful conversation. This happens on a daily basis, but today, the results are a bit more tragic than usual.

(Fred and Henry are both picking up the morning paper at 7:08, as usual. Fred approaches Henry to criticize and aggravate him; Henry sees Fred approaching and takes a deep breath to prepare for the incoming attack... as usual.)

FRED
Morning, Henry.

HENRY
It is a good morning indeed. Beautiful day.

FRED
I didn't say anything about the morning being good at all. I woke up choking on my own mucus again. Thick, brown spongy mucus. My back popped like a 21 gun salute when I got out of bed. And Gail hasn't even started cooking the eggs yet. I'm gonna be inside with my paper and have nothing to eat like some kind of a hobo. Can you believe that? A hobo in my own house.

HENRY
Well, I am sorry to hear that, Fred. I already had breakfast. I had a piece of leftover lemon pie and finished it with a cup of coffee. Heard the birds singing and thought I might as well come on outside and get the paper.

FRED
You heard the birds singing? You know why they're singing don't you?

HENRY
Well, no, not really. I just know it sounded nice to me.

FRED

They're singing because they are getting ready to mate. And they aren't really even singing anyway. They are calling out like some kind of desperate boys at a frat party. It's all they do. So, in essence, you were eating pie while birds are doing the hokey pokey right in your backyard. And that's your idea of a nice morning?

HENRY
Well, since you put it that way, I figure if I was them birds I'd be singing, too. (He laughs to himself. Fred isn't amused in the least.) Oh come on, Fred, they're just birds. You take things too seriously.

FRED
Oh, you wanna have that discussion again, huh? I take myself too seriously? Me? Remember that you are the one that has to eat pie in the corner because you know your wife isn't in there making eggs for you.

HENRY
Don't bring my wife into this, Fred.

FRED
You said that I take myself too seriously. You *would* know. You are married to the most serious person in the neighborhood.

HENRY
My wife is a decisive person, yes.

FRED
(He laughs.) Decisive? That's one way to put it.

HENRY
Well, if you want to spend your time fussing at me, I think I'll pass today. After all, you need to go get your overcooked eggs. At least if my wife does make eggs, they won't be as dry as an old sandbag.

FRED
How dare you mock my wife's cooking!

HENRY
I am just repeated what I hear you say every other day, Fred. I've never even had your wife's eggs.

FRED
And you never will! You'll just keep eating your pie in the corner like a little child hiding from his old grandmother!

HENRY
Old grandmoth... Now, you listen here...

FRED
Oh, what are you going to do, get your birds after me?

At this point the wives will both make their first appearance. It is preferred that we never actually see them. Each of the men could step behind the other one and play the part of his neighbor's wife. We would then only watch each man's reactions. But, this is only a suggestion.

(Gail enters.)

Gail
Fred, what are you shouting about?

FRED
Nothing, Gail, we were just discussing the paper... (He quickly fumbles through it) yes... about the recent, uh, bird migration. It's a darn shame. Darn shame!

GAIL
But you hate birds, Fred.

FRED
Yes, well, hopefully they'll take their bird flu with them. Are the eggs ready?

GAIL
Yes. They are a bit overcooked, though. But, you can use some hot sauce on them.

(Gail exits. Henry chuckles in a mocking way.)

FRED
Okay, I'll be there in a minute. Don't look at me like that. At least I have eggs. You couldn't beg your way into a plate of overcooked eggs if you wanted to.

HENRY
Oh you think so, do you? Iris? Iris, dear? Sweetheart, are you there?

(Iris steps outside.)

IRIS
What can you possibly need, Henry? I am in the middle of my show and you know I don't trust this "DRV" (we know it's actually "DVR") recording thing to work. Is it about the fact that you left your plate out on the table for me to wash or the fact that you ate both pieces of pie and left me nothing? Because if it is, I don't forgive you.

(Iris exits. Now, it is Fred who's laughing.)

HENRY
It's nothing, darling. It can wait. I'll buy you another pie later, okay? Honey?

FRED
I believe that is called "storming off", if I am correct. (He laughs again.) "Bad little Henry" left his plate out again. She's probably going to send you to your room.

(Henry is starting to lose his nerve.)

HENRY
Listen, what goes on in my house is my business, okay?

FRED
So, you still think she's gonna cook you some eggs? (He laughs again.)

HENRY
Well, we know your wife certainly isn't able to cook some that you can eat, unless you dump a a bottle of hot sauce on them!

FrED
Well, my wife might overcook eggs but at least she is not in line to be the wicked witch for Halloween either!

HENRY
You take that back, now!

FRED
I certainly will not!

(Gail re-enters.)

GAIL

Fred, why are you still shouting?

FRED
I AM NOT SHOUTING! Now go back in the house and make me some decent eggs!

(Gail exits. Fred freezes and realizes that he has really hurt her feelings.)
Gail, wait, I was just kidding. Gail?

HENRY
I think you call that "storming off" if I am correct?

(Fred is fuming now.)

FRED
Henry, I have had it with your smart aleck little comments! Why don't you just go back in your house and wait for the next bird show in the backyard! That's probably the only place that you're wanted anyway!

(Henry just stands there for a minute.)

HENRY
Maybe you're right. But at least I know how to treat my wife... With decency and respect! At least I know to act like a gentlemen, not an old bitter nincompoop like you!

FrED
Nincompoop? That's the best you've got? You are a small, dainty little man, aren't you?

HENRY
Fred, that's enough.

FRED
That's why your wife treats you like a little child. Because you aren't a man. You're a gentle little Nancy!

HENRY
Fred, I am warning you, that's enough.

FRED
Your wife is tougher than you every could be, NANCY!

HENRY
That's it!

(Henry punches Fred as hard as can. Fred writhes in pain as Iris walks outside.)

FRED
Ow! Oh!

HENRY
Fred? Are you okay? Fred?!

IRIS
Henry, what on earth happened? Did Fred finally have a heart attack?

HENRY
No, I think I killed him, Iris. He isn't moving at all.

IRIS
What? You killed him? Honey, I never thought you could do it! I am so proud of you!

HENRY
Proud? But, he's dead!

IRIS
I'll go and make some eggs... With cheese all over them!

(Iris exits.)

HENRY
Wait, Iris? (He notices that Fred moves.) Fred? Fred! You're alive!

(Henry helps Fred up to his feet.)

FRED
Ow... Henry you...

HENRY
I thought you were dead.

FRED
Dead? You couldn't kill me if you wanted to.

HENRY

You're bleeding.

FRED
Of course I'm bleeding. You punched me in the face, you idiot.

(Gail enters.)

GAIL
Fred? Fred what happened? Why are you bleeding?

FRED
Well... (he looks at Henry.) I think a bird swooped down and pecked me in the face. I'll be fine. I think your eggs are just what I need right now. Did you throw them out?

GAIL
Of course I did. You hurt my feelings.

FRED
I'm sorry, Gail. I love your eggs just the way they are. Will you forgive me? Gail?

GAIL
I'll start some fresh eggs. (She exits.)

FRED
Look, Henry. I, uh, I owe you an apology, too. I never thought you would actually hit me. I respect that, I do. But you could never kill me.

HENRY
Kill you? (He realizes.) Oh, Henry, you have to go inside now!

FRED
Why?

HENRY
Iris thinks I killed you and if she sees you I may not get those eggs.

FRED
She's making you eggs because she thinks you killed me?

HENRY
Yes! And this offer isn't gonna hold if you're standing out here.

FRED
Okay, Henry. Go enjoy your eggs, okay. Maybe I'll come back to life tomorrow and we can start over.

HENRY
Yeah, That sounds good, Fred. See you tomorrow, then.

FRED
Okay.

HENRY
Iris? Have I ever told you about why the birds are always singing?

IRIS
I know why they are singin'. We're stickin' with eggs today!

BlACKOUT.